Azure AI Platform Architect Roadmap 2026

From cloud, network and platform engineer to the architect who runs AI safely at enterprise scale

Foundations · Network plane · Governance and security · AI and app plane · Operate and lead

1 GenAI fundamentals

Tokens, TPM, embeddings, RAG, agents, tool calls, MCP
AI-901 (optional)

2 Microsoft Foundry

Resource vs project, deployment types, PTU, keyless auth
Agent Service standard setup

3 The app plane

App Service, Functions, Container Apps
App Gateway WAF ingress, VNet integration egress

4 Private networking for AI

Private endpoints + DNS zones, DNS Private Resolver
Firewall egress, hub-spoke and vWAN, managed VNet

5 AI gateway (API Management)

Token limits, chargeback metrics, semantic cache
Content safety, backend pools, MCP gateway

6 Governance and Azure Policy

Approved models, no keys, no public access, residency
EPAC policy as code: audit, then deny

7 Security for AI and agents

Defender for AI, Agent 365, Entra Agent ID
Prompt Shields, Purview, OWASP LLM and Agentic Top 10

8 RAG and agent building blocks

AI Search, Agent Service, Agent Framework 1.0
MCP on Azure, AKS / Container Apps hosting

9 IaC and landing zones

AI Landing Zones, ALZ accelerator, AVM
Bicep, Terraform + AzAPI, GitHub Actions OIDC

10 Observability and FinOps

Tracing, token metrics, cost per team
PTU vs pay-as-you-go, spillover pattern

11 Regulated industries

OSFI E-23 model risk (May 2027), OSFI B-13
Model inventory, evidence, IAPP AIGP

12 AI-assisted platform engineering

Copilot / Claude Code for IaC and policy
Azure MCP Server, you stay the reviewer

Certification spine

AI-901 (optional) → AI-103 → SC-500 → AZ-305 → AZ-700 / SC-100 / IAPP AIGP

github.com/vnigam1985/azure-ai-platform-architect